Current Affairs 14-11-2026

Credit - Drishti Ias

Balancing Economic Growth and Air Quality in India

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For Prelims: Environmental Performance Index , International Energy Agency , Flue Gas Desulfurization , PM2.5 , Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana , National Clean Air Programme (NCAP)

For Mains: Sustainable development and balancing economic growth with environmental protection, Environmental governance

Source: TH

Why in News?

The debate over balancing **economic growth with environmental protection** has gained attention following India's poor performance in the **2026 Environmental Performance Index (EPI)** , where it ranked **176 th out of 177 countries** and **175 th in air quality** .

- A study published in *Nature Sustainability* found that aerosol pollution reduced India's solar power generation by **9.6% in 2023** , while the **State of Global Air 2025** report estimated that more than 20 lakh deaths in India in 2023 could be attributed to air pollution.

Summary

- **India must balance economic development with air quality improvement** , as pollution damages public health, labour productivity, energy generation and long-term economic growth.
- The way forward lies in **clean technology, airshed-based governance, stronger emission standards, affordable clean energy and outcome-based pollution control** to achieve sustainable development and Viksit Bharat @2047.

What are the Challenges in Balancing Economic Growth with Air Quality for India?

- **Economic Growth with Air Quality Conflict:** The core activities that drive India's development industries, coal-fired power plants, freight transport, and agriculture are also the primary sources of emissions.
  - Upgrading to clean technology requires massive capital, which many fear could slow industrial output and economic growth.
- **Energy-Emission Paradox:** According to the **International Energy Agency (IEA)** , India's electricity demand will grow by an average of **6.4% annually through 2030** . While renewable solar energy is projected to meet half this demand, **coal will still account for at least 25%** , sustaining a high baseline of industrial emissions.
- **Policy Dilution for Cost-Effectiveness:** Implementing advanced pollution control technology (like **Flue Gas Desulfurization**) requires immense capital.
  - In **July 2025, the Union government relaxed mandatory Sulphur Dioxide (SO 2) emission norms** for several coal-fired power plants. The rationale was to control electricity prices and water consumption.
  - However, SO 2 is a primary precursor to the highly toxic **PM2.5 (fine particulate matter),** illustrating the tough trade-offs policymakers face.
- **"Sustained Use" Behavioral Challenge:** Providing clean technology does not guarantee its use.
  - Under the **Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana** , millions gained LPG access.
  - However, high cylinder refill costs relative to household income often force the rural poor to revert to **burning biomass, perpetuating lethal indoor** and ambient air pollution.
- **Fragmented Governance vs. The Airshed:** Air pollution is a transboundary issue. India's current administrative approach fights pollution city-by-city (e.g., Delhi vs. Haryana), ignoring the **Airshed approach** required to tackle meteorological zones like the **Indo-Gangetic Plain** as a single ecological unit.
  - The city-by-city approach creates a collective-action problem where one city suffers from the pollution generated by a neighboring state (e.g., **stubble burning)** .
- **Economic Cost of Pollution:** The perceived trade-off between economic growth and pollution control is misleading, as pollution itself causes significant economic losses.
  - Smog reduced India's solar power generation by **9.6% in 2023** by blocking sunlight.
  - According to a **Dalberg Advisors–Clean Air Fund assessment** , air pollution cost India an estimated **USD 260 billion (around 6% of GDP) in 2024** , partly due to reduced worker productivity, healthcare costs and premature deaths. **Presenteeism** , where employees work while ill with reduced productivity, is a major contributor.
- **Climate Masking Paradox:** Aerosols (pollution particles) scatter solar radiation and exert a cooling effect. A sudden removal of aerosols without reducing greenhouse gases could unmask this cooling, leading to a sudden spike in extreme heat.
- **Over-focus on PM10 over PM2.5:** While cities have shown success in reducing PM10 (dust), **PM2.5** (fine, highly toxic particles that often form secondarily from industrial gases like SO2 and NOx) **remains dangerously high.**
  - **Falling PM10 does not guarantee a falling PM2.5 trend.**

Air Pollutants

Sulphur Dioxide (SO_2)

It comes from the consumption of fossil fuels (oil, coal and natural gas). Reacts with water to form acid rain.

Impact: Causes respiratory problems.

Ozone (O_3)

Secondary pollutant formed from other pollutants (NOx and VOC) under the action of the sun.

Impact: Irritation of the eye and respiratory mucous membranes, asthma attacks.

Nitrogen Dioxide (NO_2)

Emissions from road transport, industry and energy production sectors. Contributes to Ozone and PM formation.

Impact: Chronic lung disease.

Carbon Monoxide (CO)

It is a product of the incomplete combustion of carbon-containing compounds.

Impact: Fatigue, confusion, and dizziness due to inadequate oxygen delivery to the brain.

Ammonia (NH_3)

Produced by the metabolism of amino acids and other compounds which contain nitrogen.

Impact: Immediate burning of the eyes, nose, throat and respiratory tract and can result in blindness, lung damage.

Lead (Pb)

Released as a waste product from extraction of metals such as silver, platinum, and iron from their respective ores.

Impact: Anemia, weakness, and kidney and brain damage.

Particulate Matter (PM)

PM10: Inhalable particles, with diameters that are generally 10 micrometers and smaller.

PM2.5: Fine inhalable particles, with diameters that are generally 2.5 micrometers and smaller.

Source: Emitted from construction sites, unpaved roads, fields, fires.

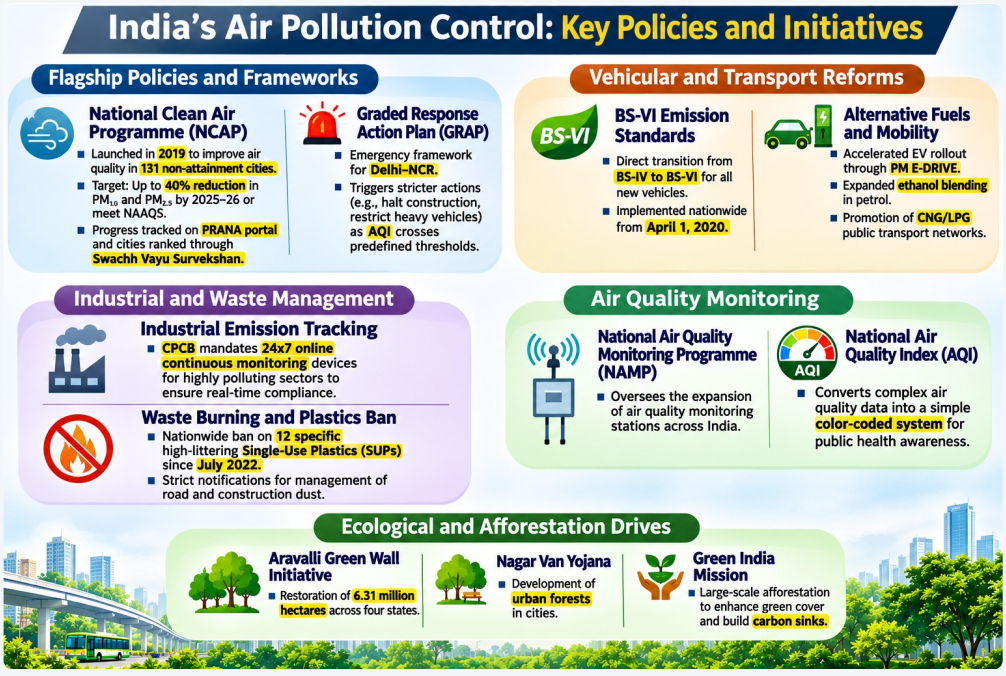
Impact: Irregular heartbeat, aggravated asthma, decreased lung function.

Note: *These major air pollutants are included in the Air quality index for which short-term National Ambient Air Quality Standards are prescribed.*



Air Quality in India

- **IQAir's World Air Quality Report 2025** : According to **IQAir's World Air Quality Report 2025** , India's population-weighted annual average PM2.5 concentration declined by **3%** , from **50.6 µg/m³ in 2024 to 48.9 µg/m³ in 2025** , improving its global ranking from **5th to 6th most polluted country** .
  - However, **New Delhi remained the world's most polluted capital** , with an annual PM2.5 concentration of **82.2 µg/m³** , while **Loni (Uttar Pradesh)** emerged as India's most polluted city at **112.5 µg/m³** .
  - The report also highlighted weak enforcement of vehicular and industrial emission norms and inadequate allocation of **National Clean Air Programme (NCAP)** funds towards industrial pollution control.
- **CREA Report on India's Air Quality (October 2026):** According to the **Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA)** , **261 out of 267 Indian cities** exceeded the **WHO's daily PM2.5 guideline of 15 µg/m³** in October 2026, while **38 cities breached India's national standard of 60 µg/m³** .
- **Environmental Performance Index (EPI) 2026:** India ranked 176th out of 177 countries, with a rank of 175th in Air Quality but 88 th in Air Pollution, highlighting the gap between emissions-related performance and health outcomes.
- **NCAP Progress:** In FY 2025–26, 108 of 130 NCAP cities recorded lower annual PM10 concentrations than in 2017–18, including 26 cities with reductions exceeding 40%.



What Measures are Needed to Balance Economic Growth with Air Quality?

- **Fostering Co-Benefits in Development:** A Dalberg–Clean Air Fund assessment estimates that a 20% reduction in India's PM2.5 pollution could avert USD 85 billion in annual economic losses by 2030,

highlighting the economic benefits of effective pollution control.

- Therefore, pollution-control measures should prioritise interventions that address multiple socio-economic and environmental challenges simultaneously.
- **Industrial Upgrades:** Enforcing the **PAT (Perform, Achieve and Trade) Scheme** and mandating **Flue-Gas Desulphurisation (FGD)** technology in thermal plants to cut toxic emissions while boosting energy efficiency.
- **Clean Cooking Transition:** Strengthening the **PMUY** with targeted, income-based LPG refill subsidies to curb lethal indoor smoke and protect maternal health.
- **Scientific Waste Management:** Leveraging **Swachh Bharat Mission-Urban 2.0** and the **GOBARdhan Scheme** to eliminate open garbage burning through **biomethanation.**

- **Adopting Regional Airshed Governance:** Establish a **regional "airshed" management system,** especially across the highly polluted Indo-Gangetic Plain.
  - Regional Airshed will ensure coordinated action against stubble burning and industrial emissions across state lines.
- **Transitioning to Outcome-Linked Funding:** Financial allocations by the **16th Finance Commission** and the **MoEFCC** (Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change) must be granted to reward verifiable, on-ground reductions in PM2.5 rather than mere expenditure on smog towers or sweeping machines.
- **Integrated Heat and Health Action Plans (HHAPs):** Aligning with **NDMA guidelines** to build localized resilience against the "climate masking" effect, preparing vulnerable populations for the temporary localized warming that occurs when cooling aerosol pollutants are removed from the atmosphere.
- **The Chinese Precedent:** Between **2005 and 2010** , while its economy expanded rapidly, China achieved a **14% drop in SO2 emissions** .
  - China accounted for 54.9% of aerosol-related solar power losses worldwide in 2023. However, by strictly retrofitting its coal plants with high-efficiency filters, it managed to reduce its pollution-related solar power loss by **1.4% every year** from 2013 to 2023, even as coal power expanded.
  - Researchers attributed this directly to strict emission controls rather than just favorable weather patterns.

Conclusion

Under **Article 21 of the Indian Constitution** , the **Right to Life inherently includes the right to a pollution-free environment.** By embracing targeted emission controls, outcome-based funding, and clean technology integration, India can fulfil its commitments to the **Sustainable Development Goals (SDG 3, 7, 8, and 13)** . The ultimate metric of a *Viksit Bharat* will not just be the size of its economy, but its ability to ensure that pollution falls significantly faster than its polluting activities grow.

> ***Drishti Mains Question:***
>
> Air pollution is an economic challenge as much as an environmental and public health crisis. Examine its implications for India's productivity, energy security and sustainable development.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the National Clean Air Programme (NCAP)?
Launched in **2019** , NCAP is India's mission-mode programme to improve air quality across **131 non-attainment cities** , targeting up to a **40% reduction in particulate matter concentrations** or achievement of NAAQS.

2. What is an airshed-based approach to pollution control?
It treats an entire geographical region sharing common atmospheric conditions as one pollution-management unit, enabling coordinated action across **cities and state boundaries** .

3. What is the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP)?
GRAP is an emergency pollution-control framework for **Delhi-NCR** that introduces progressively stricter measures based on AQI levels, including construction restrictions and curbs on certain vehicles.

4. What is the climate masking effect of aerosols?
Aerosols scatter and reflect incoming solar radiation, producing a temporary cooling effect. Their removal without simultaneous greenhouse gas reductions may reveal additional warming.

5. How does Article 21 relate to air pollution?
The Supreme Court has interpreted **Article 21 (Right to Life)** to include the right to a clean and healthy environment, making environmental protection an important constitutional obligation.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/uyFaiYufBhM**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. Artificial way of causing rainfall to reduce air pollution makes use of (2025)

a) silver iodide and potassium iodide

b) silver nitrate and potassium iodide

c) silver iodide and potassium nitrate

d) silver nitrate and potassium chloride

Ans: (a)

Q. How is the National Green Tribunal (NGT) different from the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB)? (2018)

1. The NGT has been established by an Act whereas the CPCB has been created by an executive order of the Government.
2. The NGT provides environmental justice and helps reduce the burden of litigation in the higher courts whereas the CPCB promotes cleanliness of streams and wells, and aims to improve the quality of air in the country.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only

(b) 2 only

(c) Both 1 and 2

(d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. Describe the key points of the revised Global Air Quality Guidelines (AQGs) recently released by the World Health Organisation (WHO). How are these different from its last update in 2005? What changes in India’s National Clean Air Programme are required to achieve revised standards? **(2021)**

1st BIMSTEC Health Ministers' Meeting Held in Colombo

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Source: DD

Why in News?

The **first BIMSTEC Health Ministers' Meeting, held in Colombo, Sri Lanka, unanimously** adopted a Joint Ministerial Statement and the **Revised BIMSTEC Plan of Action on Public Health (2026–2030) to strengthen regional healthcare cooperation** , and access to affordable, quality healthcare.

What are the Key Highlights of the First BIMSTEC Health Ministers' Meeting?

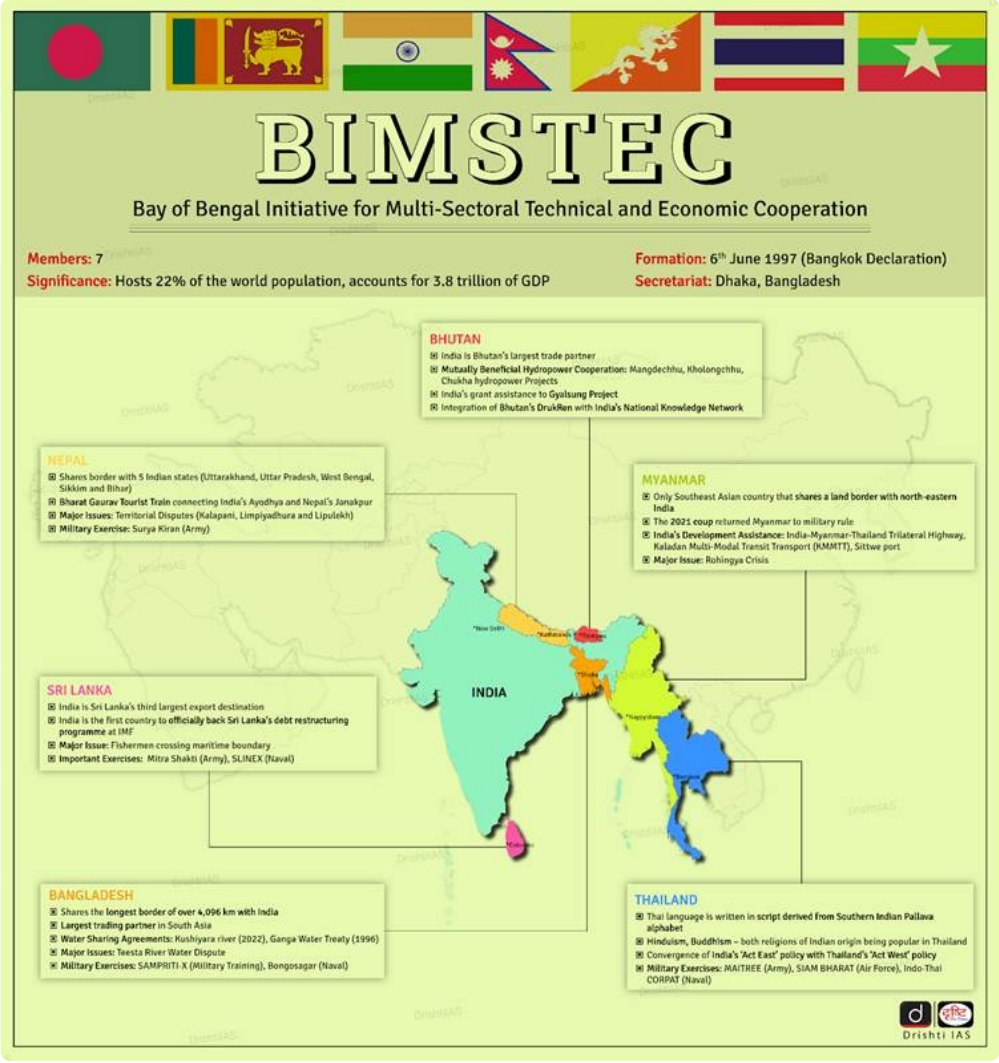
- **About the Meeting** : Attended by health ministers and representatives of the **seven BIMSTEC member countries, namely Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Myanmar, Nepal, Sri Lanka and Thailand.**
  - Held following the decision at the **6th BIMSTEC Summit** **in Bangkok (April 2025),** it reviewed cooperation in public health and traditional medicine and identified measures to strengthen regional health institutions.
- **Regional Health Roadmap:** The **Revised BIMSTEC Plan of Action on Public Health (2026–2030)** prioritises disease surveillance, pandemic preparedness, antimicrobial resistance, digital health, traditional medicine, **One Health approach** and healthcare workforce development.
- **Health Security and SDGs:** The Joint Ministerial Statement reaffirmed commitments to **Universal Health Coverage (UHC)** and **Sustainable Development Goal 3 (Good Health and Well-being),** emphasising equitable healthcare access and coordinated responses to cross-border health threats.
- **Digital Health Cooperation:** Member countries agreed to explore a proposed **BIMSTEC Digital Health Framework** to promote telemedicine, interoperable electronic health records and artificial intelligence in diagnostics and disease modelling.
- **Regional Health Institutions:** The meeting welcomed proposals and initiatives for:
  - **BIMSTEC Regional Centre of Excellence for Public Health** in Sri Lanka.
  - **BIMSTEC Centre of Excellence on Tropical Medicine** in Thailand.
  - **Regional Zoonotic Disease Observatory and Early Warning System** , proposed by Bangladesh.
- **Future Meetings:** BIMSTEC Health Ministers' and Senior Officials' Meetings will be held **biennially** , with Thailand offering to host the **second Health Ministers' Meeting in 2028** .

What are India's Key Initiatives and Contributions to BIMSTEC Health Cooperation?

- **India's Healthcare Initiatives:** India highlighted its achievements in improving healthcare access and offered to share its expertise with BIMSTEC member countries.
  - **Ayushman Arogya Mandirs** **:** Over **1.85 lakh primary healthcare facilities** providing comprehensive primary healthcare services.
  - **AB PM-JAY** **:** Cashless hospitalisation coverage of up to **₹5 lakh per eligible family annually** .
  - **eSanjeevani** **:** Over **50 crore teleconsultations** through India's national telemedicine service.
  - **Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission (ABDM)** **:** Development of an interoperable digital health

ecosystem.

- **Centre of Excellence in Traditional Medicine:** India announced its commitment to establish the **BIMSTEC Centre of Excellence in Traditional Medicine** at the **Institute of Teaching and Research in Ayurveda (ITRA), Jamnagar, Gujarat** , to promote collaborative research, capacity building, knowledge exchange and evidence-based traditional medicine practices.
- **India–Sri Lanka Ambulance Cooperation:** On the sidelines of the meeting, an MoU was exchanged to supply **100 additional fully equipped ambulances** to Sri Lanka's **1990 Suwa Seriya Emergency Ambulance Service** , with Indian grant assistance of approximately **USD 5.28 million** .
- **Health ATMs for Sri Lanka:** India announced support for **50 Medical Kiosks (Health ATMs)** with grant assistance of up to **SLR 225 million** .
  - These will provide point-of-care diagnostics and telemedicine services at Sri Lanka's Arogya Primary Health Centres.
  - The initiative forms part of India's **USD 450 million rehabilitation package** following **Cyclone Ditwah (2025)** .



Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. Where was the first BIMSTEC Health Ministers' Meeting held, and what were its major outcomes?
It was held in Colombo, Sri Lanka, in November 2026, adopting a Joint Ministerial Statement and the Revised BIMSTEC Plan of Action on Public Health (2026–2030).

2. Where will India establish the BIMSTEC Centre of Excellence in Traditional Medicine?
India will host the proposed centre at the Institute of Teaching and Research in Ayurveda (ITRA), Jamnagar, Gujarat, to promote traditional medicine research, institutional cooperation and capacity building.

3. What healthcare assistance did India announce for Sri Lanka?
India announced support for 100 additional ambulances, worth approximately USD 5.28 million, and 50 Medical Kiosks/Health ATMs to strengthen emergency and primary healthcare services.

4. When will the next Health Ministers' Meeting be held?
Thailand has offered to host the second Health Ministers' Meeting in 2028.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/WJSEFULB9Ms]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. The term 'Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership' often appears in the news in the context of the affairs of a group of countries known as (2016)

(a) G20

(b) ASEAN

(c) SCO

(d) SAARC

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. Do you think that BIMSTEC is a parallel organisation like the SAARC? What are the similarities and dissimilarities between the two? How are Indian foreign policy objectives realized by forming this new organisation? **(2022)**

Nutrient-Based Subsidy (NBS) Scheme: Rabi 2026–27

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Source: PIB

Why in News?

The Union Government approved the **Nutrient-Based Subsidy (NBS) rates for Phosphatic and Potassic (P&K) fertilisers for the Rabi season 2026-27** , aiming to ensure the availability of key fertilizers at affordable prices and promote balanced agricultural nutrient use.

What are the Key Highlights of the Nutrient-Based Subsidy (NBS) Rates for Rabi 2026-27?

- **Financial Outlay and Duration:** The revised rates are applicable from **1 st October 2026 to 31 st March 2027** , with a tentative budgetary outlay of **Rs 62,370 crore** - a significant **64% increase** over the previous Rabi season.
  - Subsidies are recalibrated for fundamental macronutrients (**Nitrogen (N), Phosphorus (P), Potassium (K), and Sulphur (S))** to align with global market trends and promote balanced soil health.
- **Key Interventions and Special Provisions:**
  - **Fixed DAP Price:** To shield farmers from global price volatility, **Di-Ammonium Phosphate (DAP) will remain available at a fixed price of Rs 1,350 per bag** , with similar provisions extended to imported/domestic **Triple Superphosphate (TSP) and Monoammonium Phosphate (MAP).**
  - **Promoting Alternatives:** A **freight subsidy for Single Superphosphate (SSP)** continues, promoting it as a cheaper, indigenous **alternative to DAP** . Subsidy on Ammonium Sulphate (alternative to Urea) will also continue.
  - **Boost to Domestic Production:** A targeted **Sulphur Package** will reimburse **domestic manufacturers 20% of their actual procurement cost** (subject to a floor price) for Sulphur and Sulphuric Acid to reduce import dependence.

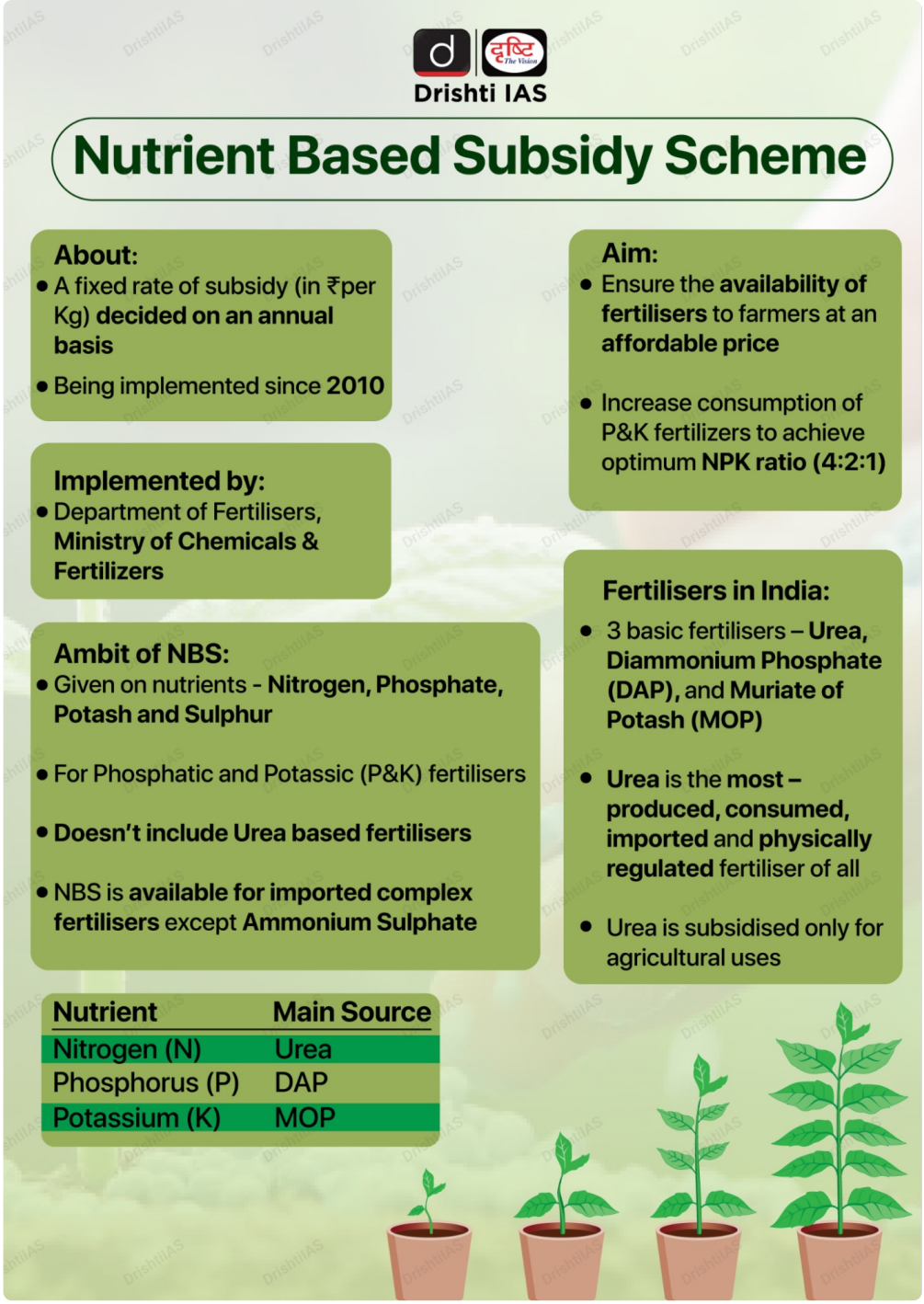
What is the Nutrient Based Subsidy (NBS) Scheme?

- **About:** The **NBS Scheme** is a **central sector agricultural policy** administered by the Department of Fertilizers under the **Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers.**
  - Implemented since April 2010, the scheme aims to ensure that farmers have access to essential fertilizers at affordable prices while promoting the balanced use of soil nutrients.
- **Key Features of the Scheme:**
  - **Nutrient-Linked Subsidies:** Under the NBS, the government does not subsidize the fertilizer product as a whole. Instead, it provides a fixed amount of subsidy per kilogram of the specific nutrients it

contains namely **Nitrogen (N), Phosphorus (P), Potash (K), and Sulphur (S)** .

- The subsidy rates are **determined on an annual or bi-annual basis for the Kharif and Rabi agricultural seasons.**

- **Fertilizer Coverage:** The scheme currently **covers 28 grades of Phosphatic and Potassic (P&K) fertilizers.**
  - This includes widely used fertilizers like DAP, Muriate of Potash (MOP), and Single Super Phosphate (SSP).
- **Decontrolled Pricing:** The P&K fertilizer sector operates under a **decontrolled, market-driven regime.**
  - Manufacturers and importers are permitted to fix the **Maximum Retail Price (MRP) at reasonable levels based on global raw material costs** . The government monitors these prices to prevent exploitation and ensure affordability.
- **Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT):** The government disburses the fixed subsidy directly to the fertilizer companies, but only after the actual physical sale to a farmer is authenticated via **Point-of-Sale (PoS) biometric/Aadhaar devices at retail outlets.**
- **Crucial Exception (Urea): Urea is excluded from the NBS regime** . It remains under a **separate statutory price-controlled mechanism where the government strictly fixes its Maximum Retail Price.**
- **Incentives for Fortification:** The scheme provides additional financial incentives for fertilizers that are customized or fortified with secondary and micro-nutrients to promote crop-specific soil health.



Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the Nutrient-Based Subsidy (NBS) Scheme?
Introduced in **April 2010** , it provides fixed per-kilogram subsidies on the nutrients **Nitrogen (N), Phosphorus (P), Potassium (K) and Sulphur (S)** in P&K fertilisers.

2. Which fertilisers are covered under the NBS Scheme?
It covers **28 grades of Phosphatic and Potassic (P&K) fertilisers** , including DAP, MOP and SSP.

3. Is urea covered under the NBS Scheme?
No. **Urea is excluded** and remains under a separate statutory price-control mechanism, with its MRP fixed by the government.

4. How does DBT operate under the NBS Scheme?
Subsidies are transferred directly to fertiliser companies after actual sales to farmers are authenticated through **Point-of-Sale (PoS) devices using Aadhaar-based authentication** .

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/OVropNwcfQw]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year's Question (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. With reference to chemical fertilizers in India, consider the following statements: (2020)

1. At present, the retail price of chemical fertilizers is market-driven and not administered by the Government.
2. Ammonia, which is an input of urea, is produced from natural gas.
3. Sulphur, which is a raw material for phosphoric acid fertilizer, is a by-product of oil refineries.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only

(b) 2 and 3 only

(c) 2 only

(d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (b)

Q. Why does the Government of India promote the use of 'Neem-coated Urea' in agriculture? (2016)

(a) Release of Neem oil in the soil increases nitrogen fixation by the soil microorganisms.

(b) Neem coating slows down the rate of dissolution of urea in the soil.

(c) Nitrous oxide, which is a greenhouse gas, is not at all released into atmosphere by crop fields.

(d) It is a combination of a weedicide and a fertilizer for particular crops.

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. How do subsidies affect the cropping pattern, crop diversity and the economy of farmers? What is the significance of crop insurance, minimum support price and food processing for small and marginal farmers? **(2017)**

Q. In what way could replacement of price subsidy with direct benefit Transfer (DBT) change the scenario of subsidies in India? Discuss. **(2015)**

Q. What are the different types of agriculture subsidies given to farmers at the national and at state levels? Critically, analyse the agricultural subsidy regime with reference to the distortions created by it. **(2013)**

One Nation One Ration Card (ONORC)

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Source: PIB

Why in News?

The **Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution** highlighted the progress of the **One Nation One Ration Card (ONORC)** initiative in strengthening nationwide food security through ration portability, digital integration and **improved Public Distribution System (PDS)** delivery, particularly benefiting migrant workers and vulnerable households.

What are the Key Facts About One Nation One Ration Card?

- **About: Launched in 2019 by the Department of Food and Public Distribution, ONORC** enables beneficiaries under the **National Food Security Act (NFSA), 2013** to access their entitled foodgrains from any **e-PoS-enabled Fair Price Shop (FPS)** across India using their existing ration cards.
  - It supports both inter-State and intra-State portability, particularly benefiting migrant workers and their families.
  - **Split Ration Entitlement:** Migrant beneficiaries **can collect their full or partial foodgrain entitlement at their destination,** while family members remaining in their home State can collect the balance using the same ration card.
- **Nationwide Coverage:** Implemented across all **36 States/Union Territories, covering 100% of Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana (PMGKAY)** beneficiaries.
- **Portability Transactions:** Approximately **3.27 crore portability transactions** are recorded every month. Since its inception, ONORC has facilitated over **233 crore transactions** , distributing more than **614 lakh metric tonnes (LMT)** of foodgrains.
- **Digitisation of PDS:**
  - **100% of ration card and beneficiary databases have been digitised across States/UTs,** covering approximately 78.65 crore beneficiaries as of October 2026.
  - **Aadhaar Seeding:** Of 20.51 crore ration cards, **98.8% (20.27 crore) are Aadhaar-seeded,** while 76.97 crore beneficiaries have been linked with Aadhaar.
  - **e-KYC:** Completed for **71.52 crore beneficiaries (91%)** as of September 2026.
- **e-PoS-enabled Fair Price Shops:** Approximately **99.8% (5.50 lakh) of India's 5.51 lakh FPSs are operational with electronic Point of Sale (e-PoS)** devices, supporting authenticated foodgrain distribution and portability.
- **Supply Chain Transparency:** Online foodgrain allocation has been implemented nationwide, while **31 States/UTs have computerised their PDS supply chains.** Online grievance redressal systems and transparency portals further strengthen accountability.
- **Rightful Targeting:** Aadhaar-linked verification and PDS data analytics help identify duplicate and potentially ineligible beneficiaries.
  - Under **Rightful Targeting Version 1** , approximately **5.95 crore suspicious records** were flagged,

resulting in the deletion of **2.58 crore duplicate or ineligible entries** following verification.

- **SARTHAK-PDS:** The **Scheme for Assistance in Ration Transport and Handling–Income with Automation in PDS (SARTHAK-PDS)** is an umbrella initiative supporting broader PDS reforms.
  - Approved for **continuation until 31st March 2031** , with a Central financial outlay of **₹25,530 crore,** it provides assistance for intra-State foodgrain transportation, handling and FPS dealers' margins while promoting technological modernisation.
  - **NIRMAL:** Strengthens PDS data architecture and analytics.
  - **SAKSHAM:** Enables real-time data integration and supply-chain monitoring, including **Vehicle Location Tracking Systems (VLTS)** .
  - **SMART-PDS (Scheme for Modernisation and Reforms through Technology in Public Distribution System):** Integrates ration card management, foodgrain distribution, supply chains and grievance redressal into a unified digital framework.

Mera Ration App

- **About:** Developed under ONORC, the **Mera Ration mobile application** , available in **13 languages** , facilitates access to ration-related information and services, particularly for migrant beneficiaries.
- **Key Features:**
  - Check monthly foodgrain entitlements and transaction history.
  - Verify Aadhaar-seeding status and national portability eligibility.
  - Access voluntary ONORC registration services.
  - Locate nearby **Fair Price Shops (FPSs)** using GPS and map-based navigation.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is One Nation One Ration Card (ONORC), and when was it launched?
ONORC was launched in 2019 by the Department of Food and Public Distribution to enable NFSA beneficiaries to access foodgrains from any e-PoS-enabled Fair Price Shop across India using their existing ration cards.

2. What is the coverage of ONORC as of 2026?
ONORC covers all 36 States/UTs and 100% of PMGKAY beneficiaries, recording over 233 crore portability transactions and distributing more than 614 LMT of foodgrains.

3. What is SARTHAK-PDS?
SARTHAK-PDS is an umbrella scheme integrating financial support for foodgrain transportation and FPS dealer margins with technology-driven PDS reforms, including SMART-PDS, NIRMAL and SAKSHAM. It has been approved for continuation until March 2031.

4. What are the key features of the Mera Ration App?
Available in 13 languages, the app enables beneficiaries to check foodgrain entitlements, view transaction histories, verify Aadhaar-seeding status and locate nearby Fair Price Shops using GPS.

5. How does ONORC strengthen food security and welfare delivery?
ONORC promotes portability of welfare benefits, migrant inclusion, transparency and efficient last-mile delivery through Aadhaar authentication, digitised ration cards and nationwide PDS integration.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/zHZCg81kQu4]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. With reference to the provisions made under the National Food Security Act, 2013, consider the following statements: (2018)

1. The families coming under the category of ‘below poverty line (BPL)’ only are eligible to receive subsidised food grains.
2. The eldest woman in a household, of age 18 years or above, shall be the head of the household for the purpose of issuance of a ration card.
3. Pregnant women and lactating mothers are entitled to a ‘take-home ration’ of 1600 calories per day during pregnancy and for six months thereafter.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2

(b) 2 only

(c) 1 and 3

(d) 3 only

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. What are the reformative steps taken by the Government to make food grain distribution system more effective? **(2019)**

India–Sri Lanka Innovation Forum Launched in Colombo

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Source: DD

The **India–Sri Lanka Innovation Forum was launched in Colombo, Sri Lanka,** as an informal, business-led platform to strengthen bilateral cooperation in startups, technology, innovation and investment.

- **About:** The forum brings together business leaders, startup founders, incubators and investors from both countries to transform growing technological cooperation into concrete business opportunities and commercial projects.
- **Key Focus Areas:**
  - **Startup Collaboration:** Connecting entrepreneurs and startups from both countries to promote cross-border innovation and joint projects.
  - **Mentorship and Knowledge Sharing:** Facilitating the exchange of expertise among established companies, incubators and startups.
  - **Investment Facilitation:** Identifying promising startups and commercially viable innovations for funding and investment.
  - **Market Access:** Helping businesses establish cross-border partnerships, access customers and expand into markets in both countries.
- **Background:** India and Sri Lanka have expanded cooperation in startups and technology over the past three years.
  - Recently, **Sri Lanka's first Atal Tinkering Lab was inaugurated at Nalanda College, Colombo** , with technical support from India's **Atal Innovation Mission (AIM) , NITI Aayog** , to promote innovation, robotics, artificial intelligence and practical technological learning.
- **Significance:** The forum aims to strengthen **bilateral economic and technological ties** , promote entrepreneurship and private-sector investment, and complement India's **Neighbourhood First Policy** .

Read More: Strengthening India- Sri Lanka Ties

Nationwide Khet Bachao Abhiyan Launched

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Source: DD

The **Union Minister for Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare** launched the nationwide **Khet Bachao Abhiyan** from Taraori in Karnal district, Haryana, to promote soil conservation, sustainable agriculture and prevention of agricultural land degradation.

- **About:** The **Khet Bachao Abhiyan was first launched on 1st June 2026 from Ramasiya village in Raisen district, Madhya Pradesh** , as a nationwide awareness campaign to promote soil health, balanced fertiliser application, natural farming, water conservation and scientific agricultural practices.
- **Current Campaign Duration:** The renewed nationwide awareness drive runs from 22nd October to 30th November 2026, focusing on preventing soil degradation and encouraging sustainable farming practices.
- **Three Key Measures for Soil Conservation:**
  - **Balanced Fertiliser Use:** Encourage farmers to use **Soil Health Cards** to identify nutrient deficiencies and apply fertilisers in appropriate quantities based on soil and crop requirements, preventing excessive nutrient application and soil degradation.
  - **Crop Rotation:** Promote cultivation of pulses such as **chickpea, lentil and pigeon pea** instead of repeatedly following the paddy–wheat cycle, as pulses improve soil fertility through **biological nitrogen fixation** .
  - **Natural Farming:** Encourage farmers to initially adopt **natural farming** **on at least half an acre** , using preparations such as **Beejamrit and Ghanjeevamrit** to reduce dependence on chemical inputs and potentially lower cultivation costs.
- **Crop Residue Management:** Discourage **stubble burning** , which causes air pollution and destroys beneficial soil microorganisms, insects and earthworms essential for maintaining soil fertility and organic matter decomposition.
- **Village-Level Outreach:** Scientists from the **Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR)** , agricultural universities and government departments will conduct village-level meetings and farmer awareness programmes to promote balanced nutrient management, crop rotation and sustainable farming practices.
- **Significance:** The campaign aims to improve **soil health, nutrient-use efficiency, agricultural productivity and environmental sustainability** through scientific farming practices and active farmer participation.

Read More: **Khet Bachao Abhiyan**